

A FIELD GUIDE

DEBUNKED

PART 6 OF 11

Mathematics and Sanskrit

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Zero. Decimal place value. The Sulba Sutras. Pingala's binary. Madhava's calculus. NASA's alleged plan to use Sanskrit. The part where many of the claims are actually true, with caveats, because Indian mathematics is genuinely one of the world's great mathematical traditions. We are going to give credit where it is due, and call out only the parts that have been inflated beyond the historical record.

A Different Tone for This Part

For five parts now I have mostly been debunking. Vimanas were not airplanes. Brahmastras were not nuclear weapons. Ganesha was not a plastic surgery patient. The pattern has been: real ancient text plus modern Hindutva inflation equals dishonest claim. The mockery has been directed at the inflation, not at the original tradition.

This part is different. Indian mathematics genuinely is one of the great mathematical traditions of world history. The zero. The decimal place-value system. The sine function. The work of Brahmagupta, Bhaskara II, and the Kerala school. The Sulba Sutras. The mathematical preface of every classical Indian astronomical text. This is real, deep, world-historical achievement. Most of the "claims" I will work through in this part are partly or substantially true.

So the tone shifts. In each chapter I will lead with a green credit box describing what is actually true and important. Then I will get into the specific inflations that are still present, the small but real distortions that turn an already-impressive story into a falsely-bigger one. The aim is not to take anything away from Indian mathematics. The aim is to make sure the credit goes to the actual achievement, accurately stated.

Real Indian mathematics is impressive enough that it does not need help. The 32-digit Indian decimal numerals that Fibonacci learned from Arabs in 1202, who learned from the Indians, are sufficient. Madhava's 1380 CE infinite series for arctangent was a 300-year head start on Newton and Leibniz. These things actually happened. The job in this part is to keep them accurately remembered, neither minimized nor exaggerated.

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Ten Mathematics and Sanskrit Claims

- 01. Zero Is an Indian Invention
- 02. The Decimal Place-Value System Is Indian
- 03. Pythagoras Stole His Theorem from Baudhayana
- 04. Calculus Was Invented in India Before Newton
- 05. Pingala Invented Binary Numbers Before Leibniz
- 06. Sanskrit Is the Most Scientific Language
- 07. NASA Will Use Sanskrit as the Language of AI
- 08. Aryabhata Invented Trigonometry (Sine Function)
- 09. Pi Was Discovered by Indians, Not Greeks
- 10. Algebra Is an Indian Invention

Same 6 step structure, but with a special green "What is True" box added at the top of each chapter. The pattern in this part is "mostly true, but with a caveat," not "mostly false." Worth marking that out clearly.

"It is India that gave us the ingenious method of expressing all numbers by means of ten symbols, each symbol receiving a value of position as well as an absolute value; a profound and important idea which appears so simple to us now that we ignore its true merit."

Pierre-Simon Laplace, French mathematician, around 1814



Real Indian mathematics. Real credit. Real caveats. Both at once.

Zero Is an Indian Invention

The Claim Zero was invented in India. Without India, the modern world would have no zero, no negative numbers, no algebra, no computer science, no modern banking, no rocket science. The British and other Europeans got everything from India and never gave proper credit.

What Is Actually True Zero as a **number with its own arithmetic properties**, the conceptual leap from "placeholder" to "real number you can do math with," is genuinely Indian. **Brahmagupta's *Brahmasphutasiddhanta* (628 CE)** contains the first known systematic rules for arithmetic with zero, including addition, subtraction, multiplication, and the (problematic) attempt at division. The Bakhshali manuscript, recently carbon-dated by Oxford in 2017 to portions as early as the 3rd to 4th century CE, contains a dot used for zero. This is real and important Indian achievement. Without India, modern arithmetic would have been delayed significantly.

Where It Came From

This claim is everywhere, from Indian school textbooks to political speeches to international tourism marketing. It is one of the most repeated and most celebrated claims about Indian intellectual heritage. And, as we will see, the core of it is right.

What Actually Happened, in Order

The story of zero has multiple parts, and Indian achievement is the largest but not the only one:

- **Babylonians, around 300 BCE.** Used a placeholder symbol (two slanted wedges) to indicate "no value in this position" in their base-60 numerals. This is the first known use of a zero placeholder. It was not used at the end of numbers and it was not treated as a number itself.
- **Mayan civilisation, around 350 CE.** Independently developed a placeholder zero in their base-20 system. Also not treated as a number to do arithmetic with.
- **India, by around the 3rd to 5th century CE.** A dot for zero appears in the Bakhshali manuscript (carbon dated by Oxford in 2017 to early portions of the 3rd to 4th century CE, though some scholars dispute the dating). Aryabhata's place-value system, around 499 CE, uses zero implicitly.
- **India, 628 CE: Brahmagupta.** This is the breakthrough. In the *Brahmasphutasiddhanta*, Brahmagupta gives explicit rules for arithmetic with zero. He treats zero as a number, not just a placeholder. He gets some things wrong (he says zero divided by zero equals zero, which is actually undefined), but the conceptual leap is made.
- **Islamic world, 8th to 9th century CE.** Al-Khwarizmi (around 825 CE) and other Islamic mathematicians adopt and transmit the Indian zero, calling Indian numerals *hindi* numerals. Al-Khwarizmi's work is later translated into Latin and reaches Europe.
- **Europe, 1202 CE.** Fibonacci's *Liber Abaci* introduces the Hindu-Arabic numerals (including zero) to Europe. Adoption takes several centuries, with Roman numerals persisting in some uses until the 16th century.

The Real Math

DEFINE: WHAT MAKES ZERO SPECIAL Zero is special because it requires you to do something philosophically strange: write down a symbol for "nothing." Most cultures find this awkward. The Greeks, despite their mathematical sophistication, did not develop a zero. Roman numerals had no zero. The conceptual leap is to recognize that "nothing" can be a number you can compute with. Once you have zero as a number, you can have negative numbers (Brahmagupta also developed rules for these). With negative numbers and zero, you can do algebra. With algebra, you can do calculus. With calculus, you can do physics. The whole structure of modern mathematics rests on having a working zero. India's role in this chain is genuinely foundational.

The Caveat

1. **Babylonians had a placeholder zero around 300 BCE, before any Indian use we have evidence for.** The Indian innovation is the leap from placeholder to "number with arithmetic properties." That is a real and important leap, but it is not "the invention of zero in every sense." The placeholder existed earlier elsewhere.
2. **"Without India, no computers" overstates the chain.** Modern binary computer arithmetic uses 0 and 1 as binary digits. The historical Indian zero is connected to this, via the decimal positional system that Indian numerals enabled, but the binary system itself was developed by Leibniz in 1679, well after the Indian zero reached Europe. Crediting India with computer science is going too far. India's contribution to the symbol and concept of zero is foundational. Crediting India with everything downstream of it is greedy.
3. **The Bakhshali manuscript dating is contested.** The 2017 Oxford carbon dating placed some birch-bark pieces in the 3rd to 4th century CE, but other Indian and Western scholars have argued the dating is for the writing surface, not necessarily the writing itself. The conservative view places the earliest reliable zero use in India at Aryabhata's time (around 499 CE), with the explicit numerical rules waiting until Brahmagupta's 628 CE text.
4. **"Europeans never gave credit" is wrong.** Pierre-Simon Laplace explicitly credited India for the place-value system in his writings around 1814 (the epigraph of this part). Western mathematicians have called Indian numerals "Hindu-Arabic" for centuries. The credit has been openly given. The bhakt who insists "Europe stole and never credited" is repeating a grievance that does not match the actual historical record.

The Honest Picture

India did invent zero as a number with its own arithmetic rules. This is one of the great conceptual achievements in human intellectual history. It is rightly celebrated. Brahmagupta's name should be remembered alongside the names of any major mathematician anywhere.

Babylonians had a placeholder zero earlier. The Indian leap was from placeholder to number, not from nothing to placeholder. This is still a huge achievement. It just is not the only step in the chain.

"Without India, no zero, no modern math, no computers" oversells a genuine achievement. The honest claim, "India made the decisive leap that enabled modern decimal arithmetic, transmitted via Arabs to Europe, and underpins every numerical calculation done today," is enough. It is impressive. It is correct.

Test Yourself

1. In what year and what text did Brahmagupta give the first systematic rules for arithmetic with zero?
2. Who had a placeholder zero before India, and approximately when?
3. When did Hindu-Arabic numerals (including zero) reach Europe in a major book?

The Decimal Place-Value System Is Indian

The Claim The decimal place-value system, in which the value of a digit depends on its position (1 in 10 means ten, 1 in 100 means hundred), is an Indian invention. Every other number system in history was clumsy in comparison. The world owes India for the basic arithmetic that every schoolchild now learns.

What Is Actually True The decimal positional system with the ten digits 0 through 9 was developed in India, fully matured by the time of Aryabhata (499 CE) and Brahmagupta (628 CE), and transmitted via the Islamic world to Europe. This system replaced Roman numerals, Greek letter-numerals, and many other awkward older notations. It is one of the most important practical inventions in the history of mathematics, because it makes computation enormously faster and more accurate. Without it, every accountant, scientist, engineer, and student would be doing arithmetic with vastly more difficulty.

What Actually Happened

The story is similar to zero's story:

- **Babylonian, around 1800 BCE.** Used a positional base-60 system. Positional, but not decimal, and missing a clean zero.
- **Chinese rod numerals, by 4th century BCE.** A decimal-like positional system used for calculation, but without a written zero.
- **India, 3rd to 5th century CE.** The Bakhshali manuscript and other early texts show a decimal positional system with a dot for zero. Aryabhata (499 CE) uses it routinely.
- **India, 7th to 9th century CE.** The system is fully standardised in Indian texts and used throughout Indian mathematics.
- **Islamic world, 8th to 9th century CE.** Al-Khwarizmi's *Al-Kitab al-mukhtasar fi hisab al-jabr wal-muqabala* (around 825 CE) describes the Indian numerals, explicitly attributing them to India. He calls them "Hindu numerals." His other book, *On the Calculation with Hindu Numerals*, is translated to Latin in the 12th century as *Algoritmi de numero Indorum* (the title from which the word "algorithm" derives).
- **Europe, 12th to 16th century.** Adoption is slow. Fibonacci's *Liber Abaci* (1202) is a major boost. By the 16th century, Roman numerals are largely retired except in ceremonial uses.

The Caveat

1. **Positional systems existed before India.** Babylonian base-60 (around 1800 BCE) is positional. Chinese rod numerals are positional. So is the Mayan base-20. The Indian innovation was to combine positional notation with the specific base of 10 (matching our fingers, which is why decimal is universal) and a fully-functioning zero. That combination is unique and Indian.
2. **The Arabs called these numerals "Hindi" and credited India explicitly.** Al-Khwarizmi was clear about the source. The "Arabic numerals" of modern parlance are actually Indo-Arabic, and the Arabs themselves never claimed otherwise. This is openly credited transmission, not theft.
3. **The European adoption took centuries.** The Indian system did not "win" instantly when it arrived in Europe. Conservative European banking, accounting, and academic communities continued using Roman numerals well into the 1500s. The change was driven by the practical superiority of the Indian system for commerce.

4. **"Every other system was clumsy" is too strong.** Roman numerals are bad for arithmetic but fine for inscription and dates. Chinese rod numerals are excellent for calculation (and the abacus, derived from them, was the dominant calculator in East Asia for two millennia). Each system has its own purpose. The Indian decimal positional system is the best for written calculation, especially in the era of paper and pen.

The Honest Picture

The decimal place-value system is a genuine and decisive Indian contribution. Every modern arithmetic operation we do, in every script and every calculator, is descended from the Indian decimal numerals. This is one of the greatest practical inventions in mathematical history.

India did not invent positional notation (the Babylonians and Chinese had it earlier). India did not invent base 10 (most counting systems use 10 because of fingers). India did invent the specific combination that became universal: base 10, ten digits including zero, positional, with explicit symbols for digits and a working zero. That combination changed the world.

This is a case where the actual story is impressive enough. Aryabhata, Brahmagupta, the unknown scribes of the Bakhshali manuscript, and many others contributed to the system that now runs every cash register and every spacecraft. Honour them. They deserve it.

Test Yourself

1. What is the difference between a "positional system" and the specific "decimal positional system"?
2. Who transmitted the Indian decimal numerals to the Islamic world, and what did he call them?
3. From whose name does the word "algorithm" derive?

Pythagoras Stole His Theorem from Baudhayana

The Claim The "Pythagorean theorem" ($a^2 + b^2 = c^2$ for a right triangle) was actually known in India centuries before Pythagoras was born. The Baudhayana Sulba Sutra, around 800 BCE, contains this exact statement. Pythagoras visited India, learned it there, took it home, and the Greeks gave him credit. The whole theorem should be renamed the "Baudhayana theorem."

What Is Actually True The Sulba Sutras (around 800 to 500 BCE) are real and important texts on the geometry of fire altar construction. **Baudhayana's Sulba Sutra**, the oldest known, does contain a clear statement of the Pythagorean relationship: "The rope stretched along the diagonal of a square produces an area double that of the square." It also gives general right-triangle relations including the specific case of $a^2 + b^2 = c^2$. This predates Pythagoras (around 570 to 495 BCE). Baudhayana deserves real credit for being among the earliest known statement of this relationship.

What Actually Happened

The story is fascinating and involves at least three independent ancient cultures discovering the same mathematical truth:

- **Babylonians, around 1800 BCE.** The Plimpton 322 cuneiform tablet, dated to around 1800 BCE, lists 15 sets of Pythagorean triples (integers a , b , c such that $a^2 + b^2 = c^2$). This is documentary evidence that the Babylonians knew the relationship a full thousand years before Baudhayana, and 1,300 years before Pythagoras. The tablet is currently held by Columbia University in New York.
- **Egyptians, by around 2000 BCE.** Used the 3-4-5 right triangle for surveying purposes. Documented in the Berlin Papyrus 6619, dated to roughly 1850 BCE.
- **India, the Sulba Sutras, around 800 to 500 BCE.** Baudhayana, Apastamba, Katyayana, Manava, all wrote sutras on fire altar geometry. Baudhayana states the right-triangle relationship clearly. The text is concerned with constructing altars of specific shapes and sizes.
- **Greece, around 570 to 495 BCE.** Pythagoras lived and worked. The first known formal proof of the theorem is attributed to him or his school. Note: **the proof, not the statement.** The statement was known long before. Pythagoras (or the Pythagoreans) appears to have produced the first rigorous deductive proof from axioms.
- **China, around 200 BCE.** The *Zhou Bi Suan Jing* contains a statement and visual proof of the theorem, independently.

The Real Math

DEFINE: STATEMENT VS PROOF In mathematics, knowing that something is true (the **statement**) is different from showing why it must be true from axioms (the **proof**). Many cultures knew the 3-4-5 right triangle and used it for practical surveying and altar construction. The Babylonians knew dozens of Pythagorean triples. The Egyptians used the rope-with-knots method (the 3-4-5 corner). The Indians used it for altar construction. The Chinese used it. These are all "statement" or "empirical" knowledge. What appears to have been Pythagorean is the first known formal proof, derived from axioms via logical deduction. This is a different kind of achievement.

The Caveat

1. **Babylonians had Pythagorean triples 1,000 years before Baudhayana.** If we are counting "first to know," Babylonians beat Indians. Bhakts who claim "India first" by 200 years over Greece often forget Babylon by 1,000 years over India.
2. **Baudhayana did not provide a proof.** The Sulba Sutras are practical handbooks for altar construction, not theoretical proofs. The first known formal proof of the theorem is from the Pythagorean school. Crediting Baudhayana with the theorem and crediting Pythagoras with the proof is the historically accurate division. Bhakts often blur these and claim Baudhayana proved it, which the surviving texts do not show.
3. **"Pythagoras visited India" is a popular claim with no good evidence.** Ancient sources mention various travels (some say Egypt, some Mesopotamia), but no contemporary or reliable source says he visited India. The travel claim is from much later Greek and Roman writers, and likely legendary.
4. **"Renaming the theorem" is a culture-war proposal, not a scholarly one.** Mathematicians actually do sometimes call it the "Pythagoras-Sulba" relation in technical writing, or specify the historical sources. The "Pythagorean theorem" name persists because it is the standard name in the global literature. The mathematics belongs to no nation.

The Honest Picture

Baudhayana stated the Pythagorean relationship clearly around 800 to 500 BCE, before Pythagoras. So did the Babylonians, 1,000 years earlier. So did the Egyptians, 1,000+ years earlier. Pythagoras (or his school) probably gave the first rigorous proof.

The honest credit goes like this. The Babylonians and Egyptians get credit for the earliest known practical knowledge of the relationship. Baudhayana gets credit for the first clear textual statement in Sanskrit, around 800 BCE. Pythagoras gets credit for the first known formal proof, around 500 BCE. The Chinese and Indians both rediscovered or refined the relationship independently in their later mathematical traditions.

This is not a story of "India first, Greece stole." It is a story of multiple ancient civilisations discovering an important geometric fact, with each making their own contributions to its understanding and proof. India's contribution is real and worth knowing. So is Babylon's. So is Greece's. None of them needs to "win."

Test Yourself

1. What is the Plimpton 322 tablet, and when does it date from?
2. What is the difference between knowing a mathematical statement and proving it?
3. What were the Sulba Sutras primarily about, in their original context?

Calculus Was Invented in India Before Newton

The Claim Calculus was invented in India by the Kerala school of mathematics, particularly by Madhava of Sangamagrama, around 1380 CE, two and a half centuries before Newton and Leibniz. The British and Europeans took this work via Jesuit missionaries and gave credit to Newton. Modern calculus is therefore an Indian invention.

What Is Actually True The Kerala school of mathematics (roughly 1340 to 1610 CE), centred in modern-day Kerala, did genuinely develop infinite series for trigonometric functions that anticipate elements of calculus by about 300 years. **Madhava of Sangamagrama** (1340 to 1425 CE) gave the infinite series for arctangent, sine, and cosine. These series are now known in Western mathematics as the Gregory-Leibniz series for $\pi/4$ (from $\arctan(1)$), the Leibniz series, and others. Madhava's work is real, was 300 years before Newton, and represents one of the most sophisticated mathematical achievements anywhere before the 17th century. The Kerala school understood limiting processes and convergent infinite series, key ingredients of calculus. This is a real and largely under-celebrated piece of world mathematical history.

What Actually Happened

The Kerala school timeline:

- **1340 to 1425 CE: Madhava of Sangamagrama.** Discovers infinite series for arctangent: $\arctan(x) = x - x^3/3 + x^5/5 - x^7/7 + \dots$ Sets $\pi/4 = 1 - 1/3 + 1/5 - 1/7 + \dots$ (the "Madhava-Leibniz" series). Also gives series for sine and cosine.
- **1444 to 1545 CE: Nilakantha Somayaji.** Refines Madhava's results in the *Tantrasangraha*. Also gives a (partial) heliocentric model for inner planets, treating Mercury and Venus as orbiting the Sun while the Sun orbits the Earth (similar to Tycho Brahe's later European model).
- **1500s to 1610: Jyeshthadeva.** Writes the *Yuktibhasa*, which contains proofs of the Kerala school results, including a proof of the arctan series. This is roughly contemporaneous with the early calculus work of Cavalieri and Fermat in Europe.

And in Europe:

- **1665 to 1666: Newton.** Develops fluxions and fluents (his version of calculus) during the plague years.
- **1675: Leibniz.** Develops his version of calculus, with the notation dx , dy , $\int$ that we still use.
- **1684: Leibniz publishes** his calculus in *Acta Eruditorum*.
- **1687: Newton publishes** the *Principia Mathematica*, which uses calculus extensively but in geometric (not algebraic) form.
- **The Newton-Leibniz priority dispute** dominates European mathematics for decades. Newton developed it earlier but published later. Leibniz published earlier. Modern consensus: both independently developed calculus.

The Real Math

DEFINE: WHAT "INVENTING CALCULUS" ACTUALLY MEANS Modern calculus has several components. (1) **Limits**: the concept of approaching a value without reaching it. (2) **Derivatives**: the rate of change of a function at a point. (3) **Integrals**: the area under a curve, the inverse of differentiation. (4) **The Fundamental Theorem of Calculus**: that differentiation and integration are inverse operations. (5) **Algebraic notation**: dx , dy , $\int$, which allow systematic manipulation. (6) **Application to physics**: Newton's use of calculus to derive planetary motion, the inverse-square law of gravitation, etc. The Kerala school had limits and infinite series (a precursor to limits). They had specific differentiation results (Nilakantha had a derivative of the sine function). They did not have the systematic algebraic notation, the explicit statement of the Fundamental Theorem, or the broad physical application. They had what we now call the calculus of trigonometric and inverse trigonometric series, but not the general framework that Newton and Leibniz developed.

The Caveat

1. **The Kerala school had infinite series and limiting processes. They did not have the full general framework of calculus.** They had specific brilliant results (the arctan series, sine series). They did not have d/dx as a universal operator, the Fundamental Theorem, or the broad physical application.
2. **"Jesuits stole and brought it to Newton" is mostly speculation.** There is a real historical question of whether Kerala mathematics influenced Europe via Jesuit missionaries (the Jesuits were in Kerala from the 1500s, the Madras Observatory and others did communicate with India). Some scholars (notably C.K. Raju in *Cultural Foundations of Mathematics*, 2007) have argued for this transmission. Other scholars (Kim Plofker, David Mumford) have found the evidence inconclusive. The honest answer is: possible transmission, not yet proven.
3. **Newton and Leibniz did real independent work.** Even if Kerala results did influence Europe, the actual systematic calculus that Newton and Leibniz developed (with general notation, the Fundamental Theorem, applications to mechanics) goes far beyond the Kerala results.
4. **"Newton stole from India" is too strong without documentary evidence.** Newton was in Cambridge in the 1660s. He had access to certain books. There is no direct documentary evidence that he had read Kerala school texts. The bhakt who insists on theft has the burden of proof to show the documentary chain.

The Honest Picture

The Kerala school is one of the most under-celebrated achievements in world mathematics. Madhava deserves to be remembered alongside Newton and Leibniz as one of the founders of mathematical analysis. The arctan series, the sine and cosine series, the use of infinite series in computing π to many decimal places, all of this is real and 300 years before Europe got there.

But "founder of analysis" is not the same as "invented calculus before Newton, who then stole." The Kerala results are pieces of what would become modern calculus. Newton and Leibniz independently developed the full framework. The intellectual relationship between Kerala and 17th-century European mathematics is an open scholarly question, with possible transmission via Jesuit missionaries being plausible but not yet documented to a high standard.

Madhava should be taught in every history-of-math course in the world. The bhakt insistence on "India invented all of calculus" is not necessary. The actual story is impressive enough.

Test Yourself

1. Who was Madhava of Sangamagrama, and what specific mathematical series is he credited with discovering?
2. What are the main components of modern calculus, and which ones did the Kerala school have?
3. What is the open scholarly question about Kerala-to-Europe transmission?

Pingala Invented Binary Numbers Before Leibniz

The Claim The Indian grammarian Pingala invented binary numbers (the base-2 system used in modern computers) in the 3rd century BCE in his Sanskrit treatise on metres, the *Chandahsutra*. Gottfried Leibniz, who is credited with the binary system in modern accounts, was a much later imitator. India therefore invented the foundation of computer science 2,000 years before Europe.

What Is Actually True **Pingala** (lived around the 3rd to 2nd century BCE), in his Sanskrit treatise the *Chandahsutra* on Sanskrit prosody (the study of metrical patterns in verse), did use a binary-like enumeration to count syllable combinations. He represented short and long syllables in patterns that map naturally to a binary number system. He also discovered what is now called Pascal's Triangle (the Meru Prastara) in this context, anticipating Blaise Pascal by about 1,800 years. This is genuine ancient Indian mathematical sophistication, often overlooked in Western histories of combinatorics.

What Actually Happened

- **3rd to 2nd century BCE: Pingala's *Chandahsutra*.** Enumerates patterns of short (laghu) and long (guru) syllables in Sanskrit verse. The enumeration can be mapped to binary numbers, with laghu corresponding to 0 and guru to 1 (or vice versa). Pingala uses this to systematically list all possible metres of a given length.
- **1679: Leibniz's binary essay.** Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz writes *De Progressione Dyadica*, the first systematic treatment of binary arithmetic, including binary addition, subtraction, multiplication, and division.
- **1703: Leibniz publishes** "Explication de l'Arithmétique Binaire" in *Mémoires de l'Académie Royale des Sciences*. This is the formal published version of his binary arithmetic, with explicit reference to and admiration for ancient Chinese hexagrams (the I Ching) which Leibniz had encountered through Jesuit missionaries.
- **1936 to 1948: Boolean algebra and computer logic.** George Boole's 1854 algebra of logic, Claude Shannon's 1937 master's thesis applying Boolean algebra to electrical switches, and Alan Turing's 1936 paper on computable numbers, together with the actual construction of early computers (Z3 in 1941, ENIAC 1945, Manchester Baby 1948), make binary the practical language of computers.

The Real Math

DEFINE: WHAT PINGALA DID VS WHAT LEIBNIZ DID Pingala used a binary enumeration of syllables. He listed patterns like "short-long-short" and "long-short-long" systematically, which is mathematically equivalent to listing binary numbers. He used this for the practical purpose of cataloguing Sanskrit poetic metres. He did not develop binary **arithmetic**: addition, subtraction, multiplication of binary numbers. He treated each pattern as a distinct entity to be catalogued. Leibniz, in his 1679 essay and 1703 publication, treated binary numbers as numbers, and gave algorithms for arithmetic operations in binary. He also explicitly noted the parallel with Chinese hexagrams. The leap from "list of patterns" to "number system you can do arithmetic with" was made by Leibniz, not by Pingala. Modern computer binary uses Leibniz's framing.

The Caveat

1. **Pingala had a binary enumeration. He did not have binary arithmetic.** Counting patterns systematically in 0s and 1s is one thing. Doing arithmetic ($101 + 11 = 1000$) in binary is another. Leibniz did the second. Pingala did not.
2. **"Modern computers come from Pingala" is too far.** The path from Pingala to modern computers would have to go: Pingala $\rightarrow$??? $\rightarrow$ Leibniz 1703 $\rightarrow$ Boole 1854 $\rightarrow$ Shannon 1937 $\rightarrow$ ENIAC 1945. There is no documented chain from Pingala to Leibniz. Leibniz himself credited Chinese hexagrams (the I Ching) as his inspiration, not Sanskrit prosody.
3. **The Pingala-Pascal Triangle connection is real and impressive.** The Meru Prastara in Pingala's text gives what is now called Pascal's Triangle, used for binomial coefficients. This is documented and credit-worthy. Halayudha (around 10th century CE), in his commentary, makes this explicit. The figure is genuinely Pingala's.
4. **The credit chain is: combinatorics (yes), binary arithmetic (no), modern computers (definitely no).** Pingala gets credit for the combinatorial framework. Leibniz gets credit for binary arithmetic. Boole and Shannon get credit for binary logic. Computer pioneers get credit for actual machines. Each step is its own contribution.

The Honest Picture

Pingala is one of the under-celebrated mathematical minds of ancient India. His combinatorial work on Sanskrit metres anticipates many later developments: binary enumeration, Pascal's Triangle, systematic combinatorics. He should be taught in every history-of-mathematics course, alongside Euclid, Archimedes, and Pythagoras.

Modern computer science rests on binary arithmetic (Leibniz), Boolean algebra (Boole), and electronic switching (Shannon, von Neumann, Turing, and many others). Pingala's contribution to this chain is at the very beginning, as a brilliant ancient Indian who showed that binary enumeration is possible. The chain has many steps after him.

The honest claim, "Pingala anticipated the binary enumeration and the binomial coefficient table 1,800 to 2,000 years before they were rediscovered in Europe," is real and impressive. The inflated claim, "India invented the basis of computer science," compresses too many steps and assigns too much credit to one ancient figure.

Test Yourself

1. What did Pingala's *Chandahsutra* primarily catalogue, and how is this related to binary?
2. What is the Meru Prastara, and what later European mathematical figure is it equivalent to?
3. What did Leibniz himself credit as his inspiration for binary, and what year did he publish?

Sanskrit Is the Most Scientific Language

The Claim Sanskrit is the most scientific language ever created. Its grammar, codified by Panini around 500 BCE, is so precise that it has no ambiguities. It is also the most computer-friendly language in existence. Sanskrit is the original language of all Indo-European languages, and possibly all human languages.

What Is Actually True **Panini's Ashtadhyayi** (around 500 to 400 BCE) is one of the most remarkable works of grammatical analysis in any culture. Panini gave a formal generative grammar for Sanskrit in about 4,000 sutras, anticipating elements of modern linguistic theory (especially generative grammar a la Chomsky) by 2,500 years. The work is concise, systematic, and breathtaking in its precision. Sanskrit grammar as analysed by Panini is a real intellectual achievement that has rightly impressed linguists for centuries. Leonard Bloomfield called the Ashtadhyayi "one of the greatest monuments of human intelligence."

What Actually Happened

- **Panini, around 500 to 400 BCE.** Composes the *Ashtadhyayi*, 4,000 sutras describing Sanskrit phonology, morphology, and syntax.
- **Patanjali, around 150 BCE.** Writes the *Mahabhashya*, a commentary on Panini, refining and extending the grammatical work.
- **Sanskrit declines as a living language** over the medieval period, persisting as a learned and liturgical language.
- **1786: Sir William Jones** recognises Sanskrit's close kinship with Greek, Latin, and other languages. This founds the modern field of Indo-European linguistics and the comparative method.
- **19th and 20th centuries.** Sanskrit grammar studied intensively by Bloomfield, Edgerton, Renou, and many others. The work of Panini is recognised as foundational to linguistics. Frits Staal called Panini's grammar "the first generative grammar."

The Real Linguistics

DEFINE: WHAT "SCIENTIFIC LANGUAGE" COULD MEAN A language can be called "scientific" in several senses. (1) Its **grammar** can be precisely specified (Sanskrit is impressive here, due to Panini). (2) Its **vocabulary** can be precise and unambiguous (Sanskrit, like English and German, is a natural language with significant ambiguity in everyday use). (3) It can be **used for science** (Sanskrit was used for ancient Indian science and astronomy, real achievements). (4) It can be **computationally parseable** (formal logical languages like Prolog and the formal calculi of mathematical logic are designed for this, but no natural language is fully so). Sanskrit is scientific in sense (1) more than any other natural language. It is not uniquely scientific in senses (2), (3), or (4). Comparing Sanskrit to English on "scientific" status is comparing apples to oranges because they are scientific in different ways.

The Caveat

1. **Panini's grammar is remarkable for its systematicity. Sanskrit itself, as spoken or written, is a natural language with the usual ambiguities.** Panini's analysis is what is impressive, not Sanskrit's intrinsic precision. Any natural language analysed with Panini-level rigour would also reveal deep structure.

2. **"No ambiguities" is wrong.** Sanskrit, like all natural languages, has homonyms, polysemous words, ambiguous syntax, and context-dependent meaning. Compound formation in Sanskrit (the famous long compounds in classical Sanskrit poetry) is notoriously ambiguous. Sanskrit pundits have spent centuries debating the meaning of contested verses.
3. **"Original language of all Indo-European languages" overstates the relationship.** Sanskrit and Proto-Indo-European are not the same. Sanskrit is one of the earliest attested Indo-European languages, and one of the best-preserved, but the actual common ancestor is Proto-Indo-European, a reconstructed (not attested) language spoken thousands of years before Sanskrit. Calling Sanskrit "the mother of all Indo-European" is roughly like calling Latin "the mother of all Romance languages": close but not technically accurate. Latin is the ancestor of Romance languages; Proto-Indo-European is the ancestor of Indo-European languages, of which Sanskrit and Latin are both daughters.
4. **"Mother of all human languages" is fringe and not supported by any mainstream linguistics.** Human languages descend from many language families (Indo-European, Sino-Tibetan, Afro-Asiatic, Niger-Congo, Austronesian, Dravidian, etc.). Sanskrit is the ancestor of a particular family of north Indian and Iranian languages, not of all human languages.

The Honest Picture

Panini's grammar is a world-historical intellectual achievement. The systematic precision of his rules genuinely anticipates modern linguistic methods. Sanskrit as a language is rich, beautiful, and has carried magnificent literature, philosophy, mathematics, and science for over two millennia.

Sanskrit is not uniquely "scientific" in any sense that gives it categorical superiority over other languages. It is a natural language with the usual ambiguities. Panini's grammar is uniquely impressive among ancient grammatical works. These are two different statements.

Sanskrit is one of the major Indo-European languages, descended from Proto-Indo-European, and one of the best-attested ancient languages. It is not the "mother of all languages." The Tower of Babel as historical claim is religious or mythological, not linguistic.

The honest celebration: Panini was a genius. His work is foundational to linguistics. Sanskrit is a great language with great literature. The inflation that adds "and Sanskrit is also superior to every other language and the mother of all" is not necessary.

Test Yourself

1. What did Panini write, around when, and how many sutras does it contain?
2. What is Proto-Indo-European, and how is it related to Sanskrit?
3. Who recognised Sanskrit's kinship with Greek and Latin, and in what year?

NASA Will Use Sanskrit as the Language of AI

The Claim NASA has officially declared Sanskrit the best language for computer programming and artificial intelligence. NASA is planning to use Sanskrit in its sixth and seventh generation computers. A NASA scientist named Rick Briggs published a paper proving Sanskrit is uniquely suited to AI. India should be proud that its ancient language has been chosen by NASA.

What Is Actually True (Mostly Not) Most of this claim is false. There is no NASA programme to use Sanskrit for computers, AI, or anything else. NASA has never declared Sanskrit "the best language for computers." The Rick Briggs paper is real and is the source of the claim, but the paper says something much more modest than the popular claim. The whole framing has become a beloved Indian internet myth. The kernel of truth (Briggs's paper) has been inflated into something the paper itself does not say.

Where It Came From

The claim traces back to a real but heavily misrepresented paper:

Briggs, Rick. "Knowledge Representation in Sanskrit and Artificial Intelligence." AI Magazine, Vol 6, No 1, Spring 1985, pages 32 to 39. Published by the American Association for Artificial Intelligence (AAAI).

The paper does exist. It is a real, peer-reviewed publication in *AI Magazine*. Rick Briggs was a researcher at NASA Ames Research Center at the time. The paper argues that Sanskrit grammarians (particularly those of the school after Panini) had developed methods of knowledge representation, particularly using semantic relations like the "karaka" framework (similar to modern semantic role labelling), that resemble methods used in modern AI knowledge representation. Briggs argues that this ancient Indian work is genuinely interesting to AI researchers and may have things to teach modern semantics.

What the paper does **not** say:

- It does not say NASA plans to use Sanskrit for computers.
- It does not say Sanskrit is "the best language for AI."
- It does not say Sanskrit will be the language of sixth or seventh generation computers.
- It does not declare Sanskrit superior to any other language.

It says: Sanskrit grammarians developed sophisticated methods for analysing meaning relations, and modern AI researchers can learn something from this work.

How the Claim Inflated

The Briggs paper was a relatively obscure academic article. Around the 1990s and into the 2000s, it began circulating in Indian newspapers, magazines, and (later) WhatsApp forwards in a heavily inflated form. The headline "NASA Says Sanskrit Best for Computers" gradually replaced the actual content of the paper. By the 2000s, the claim "NASA will use Sanskrit in sixth-generation computers" was a fixture of Indian motivational content. Government officials, including Indian Prime Ministers, have referenced it. None of the claims about NASA's plans match anything NASA has ever officially said.

The Real Computer Science

DEFINE: WHAT COMPUTERS ACTUALLY USE Modern computers run on binary (0 and 1) at the hardware level. At higher levels, they run on programming languages like C++, Python, Java, JavaScript, and many others. These languages are designed for specific purposes (system programming, scripting, web development) and are constantly evolving. AI systems use specialized representations including neural network weight matrices, attention layers, embedding spaces, and various specialized data structures. Natural languages, including Sanskrit, are **not** programming languages and are not used as programming languages in any deployed AI system. The Briggs paper was about how Sanskrit grammatical theory might inform certain aspects of AI semantic representation, not about Sanskrit being a programming language.

The Debunk

1. **NASA has no Sanskrit programme.** Verifiable from NASA's own public statements and budget documents. There is no Sanskrit-for-computers project. There never has been.
2. **The Briggs paper, the actual source, says something much more modest.** It says Sanskrit grammar has interesting structural features that AI researchers can learn from. It does not say Sanskrit will replace programming languages.
3. **"Sixth-generation computer" is not even a well-defined term.** Generations of computers are roughly defined by hardware (first: vacuum tubes; second: transistors; third: integrated circuits; fourth: microprocessors; fifth: parallel and AI computing, the term used in Japan's 1980s AI project). There is no agreed sixth or seventh generation. The "Sanskrit in sixth-generation computers" claim is using a term that does not map cleanly to current computer science.
4. **Programming languages have specific design requirements (formal syntax, unambiguous parsing, low computational overhead) that natural languages do not meet.** Sanskrit, despite Panini's grammar, has the kinds of ambiguities and contextual elements that make it unsuitable as a programming language. C, Python, and Lisp are all designed for unambiguous machine interpretation.
5. **The Briggs paper is interesting on its own terms.** Read it. It is short and accessible. It is the actual source. The exaggerated version that circulates on the internet is not what Briggs said.

The Honest Picture

Panini's analysis of Sanskrit and the related work of later Indian grammarians on semantic theory is a real and impressive intellectual heritage. Some elements of this work do parallel modern computational linguistics and AI semantic representation. Rick Briggs's 1985 paper is a legitimate scholarly contribution noting this parallel.

NASA has no Sanskrit programme. Programming languages are not chosen for "scientific" reasons; they are designed for specific computational tasks. Sanskrit is not a programming language and has not been adopted as one.

The honest celebration: Panini and the later Indian grammarians did sophisticated work that has parallels to modern computational semantics. Read Briggs's actual paper. Stop forwarding the inflated WhatsApp version. Real Sanskrit grammatical heritage is impressive. The NASA-will-use-Sanskrit story is false. Both are facts.

Test Yourself

1. In what journal and year did Rick Briggs publish his Sanskrit and AI paper?
2. Does NASA have a programme to use Sanskrit for computers? What is the evidence?
3. What does Briggs's actual paper argue, in its own terms?

Aryabhata Invented Trigonometry (Sine Function)

The Claim Aryabhata invented trigonometry, specifically the sine function, in 499 CE. Before Aryabhata, no one in the world had a proper trigonometric function. The word "sine" itself comes through Arabic from Sanskrit, proving Indian origin.

What Is Actually True Aryabhata gave the first known tabulation of **half-chord values**, which is mathematically equivalent to the modern sine function. He called this quantity **jya** (or sometimes **jya-ardha**, "half-chord"). His sine table gives values for 24 angles between 0 and 90 degrees, and is reasonably accurate. This is the start of trigonometry in its modern form. The word "sine" does indeed come from Sanskrit via Arabic: $jya \rightarrow$ Arabic *jiba* (loanword) $\rightarrow$ misread as *jaib* (Arabic for "bay" or "fold") $\rightarrow$ Latin *sinus* (Latin for "fold or bay") $\rightarrow$ English *sine*. The etymology proves the transmission.

What Actually Happened

- **Ancient Greeks, around 150 BCE: Hipparchus.** Tabulated chords of circles for astronomical purposes. This is the precursor to trigonometry. Hipparchus is often called the founder of trigonometry. His chord tables are the ancestors of all later trigonometric tables.
- **Ptolemy, 2nd century CE.** Refined chord tables in the *Almagest*. Used base-60 fractions for precision.
- **Aryabhata, 499 CE.** Introduces **jya**, the half-chord, instead of the full chord. This is a major improvement because $jya = \text{sine}$, and sine is more useful in calculations than chord. Aryabhata gives a table of *jya* values for 24 angles.
- **Brahmagupta, 628 CE; Bhaskara II, 1150 CE.** Refine the sine table to higher accuracy.
- **Madhava of Sangamagrama, 1380 CE.** Gives infinite series for sine, cosine, and arctangent (see Chapter 4).
- **Islamic world, 9th to 13th centuries.** Adopts and refines Indian trigonometry. The half-chord (Sanskrit *jya*) becomes Arabic *jiba*, then misread as *jaib*.
- **Europe, 12th century onward.** Receives the Arabic translations. Gerard of Cremona translates Arabic mathematical works to Latin. *Jaib* gets translated as *sinus*, the Latin word for "fold" or "bay" (because of the misreading). *Sinus* becomes our modern "sine."

The Real Math

DEFINE: SINE VS CHORD For a circle of radius 1, the **chord** of an angle θ is the straight-line distance between two points on the circle separated by an arc of angle θ . The chord is what the Greeks tabulated. The **sine** of an angle θ is the y-coordinate of a point at angle θ on the unit circle, or equivalently, half the chord of double the angle. The sine is what the Indians tabulated. Sine is more useful than chord because it relates more directly to right-triangle ratios ($\text{sine} = \text{opposite} / \text{hypotenuse}$), which is what most practical calculations need. The Indian innovation was to switch from chord tables to half-chord (sine) tables. This is a real and lasting contribution that all modern trigonometry uses.

The Caveat

1. **Aryabhata invented the sine function. He did not invent trigonometry.** Trigonometry, in the broad sense (the study of triangles, their angles, and the ratios of their sides), goes back to the Greek geometers and astronomers, especially Hipparchus (around 150 BCE). The Indian innovation was a critical refinement (sine instead of chord), not the invention of the whole field.

2. **"Sine" comes from Sanskrit by transmission, not as direct loan.** The Sanskrit word *jya* became the Arabic word *jiba* (a loanword), then was misread as *jaib* (the same Arabic letters can be read with different vowels). The Latin word *sinus* is a translation of *jaib*, not of *jya*. So "sine" preserves an Indian-via-Arabic chain, but through a famous translator's misunderstanding. The etymology is fun and absolutely Indian-derived, but not direct.
3. **Indian and Islamic and European trigonometry built on each other in turn.** The progression from Greek chord to Indian sine to Arabic refinement to European calculus is a model of transmission across cultures. Indian achievement is critical, but not solo.
4. **Modern trigonometry (sin, cos, tan, cot, sec, csc, all six functions) was not in Aryabhata.** He had sine. Cosine (*kojya*, "complement of *jya*") was added in Indian tradition. Tangent and cotangent came later, mostly via Arabic and European refinements. Modern unified trigonometry is a product of many cultures over many centuries.

The Honest Picture

Aryabhata's introduction of the sine function (*jya*, half-chord) is one of the most important refinements in the history of trigonometry. It made trigonometric calculation faster, more accurate, and easier to combine with other mathematical operations. The Indian sine table influenced all later trigonometry, Arabic and European.

The word "sine" itself preserves the Indian origin, transmitted via Arabic with a famous translator's misreading. The etymology is fun and is documented in standard histories of mathematics.

"Aryabhata invented trigonometry" overstates by a small amount. He invented the sine function, which is the modern trigonometric primitive. He did not invent the broader field of triangle-relations, which is older. The honest credit, "Aryabhata introduced the sine function around 499 CE, transforming trigonometry from chord-based to half-chord-based, and the half-chord is what we still use today," is precise and impressive.

Test Yourself

1. What Sanskrit word did Aryabhata use for the half-chord (which we now call sine)?
2. Trace the etymology of the English word "sine" from Sanskrit through Arabic to Latin.
3. Who tabulated chord values for astronomical purposes before Aryabhata?

Pi Was Discovered by Indians, Not Greeks

The Claim The mathematical constant π (pi) was first computed accurately by Indian mathematicians, not Greeks. Indian astronomers gave more accurate values of π centuries before Archimedes. Modern computer calculations of π to billions of digits are descended directly from Indian techniques.

What Is Actually True **Aryabhata in 499 CE** gave π as approximately 3.1416 (four decimal places of accuracy), calling it "approximate" (asanna), with an honest acknowledgement of its irrational nature. **Bhaskara II in 1150 CE** gave $\pi = 3.14156$. The greatest Indian achievement on π was by **Madhava of Sangamagrama around 1400 CE**, who developed the infinite series $\pi/4 = 1 - 1/3 + 1/5 - 1/7 + \dots$, now called the "Madhava-Leibniz series" because James Gregory and Leibniz rediscovered it in Europe in the 17th century. Madhava used this and related series to compute π to 11 decimal places around 1400 CE, far ahead of European accuracy at the time. This is a real and largely under-credited Indian achievement.

What Actually Happened

- **Egyptian Rhind Papyrus, around 1650 BCE.** Gives $\pi \approx 256/81 \approx 3.1605$, accurate to about 1%.
- **Babylonian, around 1900 BCE.** Used $\pi \approx 25/8 = 3.125$. Also from a tablet listing the constants of the circle.
- **Sulba Sutras (Baudhayana etc.), around 800 to 500 BCE.** Use π values around 3.088 to 3.16, depending on the formula.
- **Archimedes, around 250 BCE.** Used the method of inscribed and circumscribed polygons (96-sided) to bound π between $223/71$ and $22/7$. This gives $3.1408 < \pi < 3.1429$, accurate to about 3 decimal places. This is the first systematic mathematical (not approximate measurement) computation of π .
- **Liu Hui, around 263 CE (China).** Used 192-sided polygons to compute $\pi \approx 3.14159$, an extraordinarily precise value for the time.
- **Zu Chongzhi, around 480 CE (China).** Computed π to 7 decimal places: 3.1415926. This was the most accurate value anywhere in the world for nearly 1,000 years.
- **Aryabhata, 499 CE.** $\pi \approx 3.1416$.
- **Madhava, around 1400 CE.** π to 11 decimal places, via infinite series. Most accurate value in the world at the time.
- **James Gregory, 1671 CE; Leibniz, 1674 CE.** Independently rediscovered the arctangent series.

The Real Math

DEFINE: HOW PI IS COMPUTED π is the ratio of a circle's circumference to its diameter. It is an irrational number (cannot be written as a fraction) and a transcendental number (not a root of any polynomial with rational coefficients). Modern computer calculations use various rapidly-convergent series, like the Gauss-Legendre algorithm or the Chudnovsky brothers' formula (1989), which converges extremely fast. In 2024, π has been computed to about 202 trillion decimal places. The fundamental methods (infinite series and iterative algorithms) have ancient and medieval roots in Greece (Archimedes' polygon method), China (Liu Hui, Zu Chongzhi), India (Madhava), and post-Renaissance Europe (Newton, Leibniz, Machin).

The Caveat

1. **Indian π values are accurate, but not always first.** Zu Chongzhi's 480 CE value (3.1415926 to 7 decimal places) preceded Aryabhata's 499 CE value (3.1416 to 4 decimal places) by 19 years. Chinese mathematicians were as accurate as or more accurate than Indians for π in this period.
2. **Archimedes gave the first rigorous bounding method.** $22/7$ (upper) and $223/71$ (lower) bound π in a rigorous mathematical sense, not just an approximation. This is a different kind of achievement, and it precedes Indian work by about 700 years.
3. **Madhava's infinite series is genuinely revolutionary.** Around 1400 CE, his series for $\pi/4$ (and related series for sine and cosine) gave a fundamentally new way to compute π , one that converges to arbitrary precision given enough terms. This is the start of analytic methods for π , and predates Newton-Leibniz by 300 years. This is the genuinely strong Indian claim on π history.
4. **"Indians discovered pi" or "Indians, not Greeks, discovered pi" is imprecise.** Many cultures discovered the existence of pi (the ratio of circumference to diameter) very early. The Egyptians, Babylonians, Greeks, Chinese, and Indians all had approximate values. The interesting question is who developed the best methods, and the answer is "different cultures excelled at different times." India peaked with Madhava in the 14th to 15th century. Greece peaked with Archimedes in the 3rd century BCE. China peaked with Zu Chongzhi in the 5th century CE.

The Honest Picture

India has a great pi history. Aryabhata's 3.1416 (with honest acknowledgement of approximation), Bhaskara II's 3.14156, and especially Madhava's infinite series and 11-decimal-place calculation around 1400 CE are major achievements. The Madhava series is genuinely 300 years ahead of European work and deserves to be in every history-of-mathematics curriculum.

"Pi was discovered by Indians, not Greeks" is the kind of claim that ignores Babylonia (1900 BCE), Egypt (1650 BCE), China (480 CE), and the rigorous method of Archimedes. Pi was discovered, refined, and computed by many cultures, with Indian achievements being one of several great peaks.

The honest celebration: Madhava's series. The honest acknowledgement: he was building on a long international tradition, and others contributed at other times. This is how human knowledge actually grows. Indian, Chinese, Greek, Arab, European mathematicians all building on each other. Pi is everyone's.

Test Yourself

1. Who computed pi to 7 decimal places in 480 CE, and from what country?
2. What is Madhava's series for $\pi/4$, and what is it called in modern Western mathematics?
3. What was Archimedes' specific contribution to the computation of pi?

Algebra Is an Indian Invention

The Claim Algebra was invented in India by Brahmagupta and refined by Bhaskara II. The Arabs took this from India and gave it the name "al-jabr." Modern algebra in school textbooks comes directly from the Indian tradition, not from any European or Arabic source. Calling it "Arabic algebra" is a Western mistake.

What Is Actually True Indian mathematicians made **major contributions** to what we now call algebra. Brahmagupta (598 to 668 CE) gave rules for arithmetic with negative numbers, the formula for solving quadratic equations, and rules for what we now call the diophantine equation. Bhaskara II (1114 to 1185 CE) gave methods for cubic and quartic equations, and the chakravala (cyclic) method for solving the Pell equation $Nx^2 + 1 = y^2$ (this method was not surpassed in Europe until the 17th century). The Kerala school added infinite series and limiting processes. Indian algebra, especially Brahmagupta's negative number rules and Bhaskara's chakravala, is one of the great medieval mathematical achievements anywhere.

What Actually Happened

- **Babylonians, around 1800 BCE.** Solved quadratic equations (without modern algebraic notation) using verbal recipes and tables. This is "rhetorical algebra" or "arithmetic algebra."
- **Greek, especially Diophantus, around 250 CE.** The *Arithmetica* introduces symbolic representation and the systematic solution of equations. Diophantus is often called the "father of algebra" in Western tradition.
- **India, Brahmagupta, 628 CE.** The *Brahmasphutasiddhanta*. Negative numbers, the quadratic formula, work on the diophantine equation.
- **Islamic world, al-Khwarizmi, around 825 CE.** Writes *Al-Kitab al-mukhtasar fi hisab al-jabr wal-muqabala*, from which we get "algebra" (from al-jabr, the restoration). Al-Khwarizmi's algebra is systematic, with classifications of equation types and solution methods. He explicitly draws on both Indian (Brahmagupta) and Greek (Diophantus) sources.
- **India, Bhaskara II, 1150 CE.** Major work in the *Bijaganita* on algebraic equations, including the chakravala method for the Pell equation.
- **European Renaissance, 1500s.** Italian mathematicians (Cardano, Tartaglia, Ferrari) develop general solutions for cubic and quartic equations, building on Arabic and Italian traditions.
- **Vieta, 1591.** Introduces systematic symbolic notation, transforming algebra from rhetorical to symbolic.
- **Descartes, 1637.** Combines algebra with geometry in analytic geometry. Modern algebraic notation (variables x, y, z , exponents, etc.) takes shape.

The Real Math

DEFINE: WHAT ALGEBRA IS Algebra is the study of mathematical operations applied to variables (symbols representing unknown values). It includes solving equations, manipulating expressions, and studying the structure of operations. Modern algebra has many branches: elementary (school) algebra, linear algebra (vectors and matrices), abstract algebra (groups, rings, fields), algebraic geometry, and many more. The historical development of algebra was a multi-culture process spanning roughly 4,000 years, from Babylonian recipes around 1800 BCE through Diophantus around 250 CE, the Indian and Islamic mathematicians of the 7th to 12th centuries CE, the Italian Renaissance for cubic and quartic equations, Vieta for symbolic notation, and into modern abstract algebra of the 19th and 20th centuries.

The Caveat

1. **The word "algebra" comes from Arabic, not Sanskrit.** Al-jabr means "the restoration" or "the reunion of broken parts" in Arabic. Al-Khwarizmi's title (around 825 CE) is where it comes from. So "algebra" is etymologically Arabic. The Indian word for algebra is bijaganita (literally "seed mathematics" or "calculation of seeds," meaning unknowns).
2. **Al-Khwarizmi credited both Indian and Greek sources.** He used Brahmagupta's work, especially on negative numbers and the diophantine equation. He also used Diophantus. His algebra is a synthesis, not "stolen from India."
3. **The Babylonians had algebra-like problems 2,500 years before Brahmagupta.** They solved quadratics. They worked with unknowns (described rhetorically). They did this without modern notation. Brahmagupta did not "invent" algebra in any clean sense; he made important contributions to an already-existing tradition.
4. **Symbolic algebra (the x , y , $+$, $=$, etc. notation we use today) is mostly European Renaissance.** Vieta in 1591 and Descartes in 1637 are the key figures. The Indian and Arabic algebras were largely rhetorical or used a limited symbolic notation, but not the modern fully-symbolic system. So "modern algebra is Indian" is not accurate; modern algebra is mostly post-Renaissance European, building on Indian and Arabic algebra and earlier Greek and Babylonian work.
5. **Brahmagupta's negative number rules and Bhaskara's chakravala are exceptional achievements.** These are not "all of algebra" but specific brilliant contributions. The honest claim is "India made major contributions to medieval algebra, especially on negative numbers and Pell equations, well ahead of European work in those specific areas."

The Honest Picture

Indian algebra is a glorious tradition. Brahmagupta's rules for negative numbers in 628 CE are foundational. The quadratic formula is in Brahmagupta. Bhaskara II's chakravala method for the Pell equation is one of the most beautiful pre-modern mathematical achievements. The bijaganita tradition continued through Mahavira (9th century), Sridhara (10th century), and Bhaskara II (12th century), and into the Kerala school (14th to 16th centuries).

The word "algebra" is Arabic, from al-Khwarizmi's 9th century work, which synthesised Indian and Greek sources. Modern symbolic algebra is European Renaissance and post-Renaissance, with major contributions from Italy, France, Germany, and Britain in the 16th to 19th centuries.

Algebra, in its history, is genuinely a multi-culture enterprise: Babylonian rhetorical problem solving, Greek systematic symbolic work, Indian negative numbers and special equation methods, Arabic systematic synthesis and naming, Italian cubic and quartic solutions, French and German Renaissance symbolic notation, modern abstract algebra. India's role is large and important. It is not all of algebra. The honest claim, which gives full credit to Brahmagupta and Bhaskara without overstating, is enough.

Test Yourself

1. What does the word "al-jabr" mean in Arabic, and who wrote the book that gives algebra its name?
2. What is the chakravala method, and which Indian mathematician is associated with it?

3. When did modern symbolic notation in algebra (the x , y , $+$, $=$ system) emerge, and from which country?

What You Just Learned and Sources

What You Just Learned

- **Zero as a number is genuinely Indian (Brahmagupta 628 CE).** Placeholder zero existed earlier in Babylonia and Maya. India made the decisive conceptual leap. "Without India, no zero" overstates by ignoring the placeholder predecessors.
- **The decimal place-value system is genuinely Indian.** Aryabhata (499 CE) had it, the Bakhshali manuscript shows it, Brahmagupta refined it. Al-Khwarizmi transmitted it to the Islamic world and called the numerals "Hindi." Fibonacci brought it to Europe in 1202.
- **Baudhayana stated the Pythagorean relationship around 800 BCE.** Babylonians had Pythagorean triples 1,000 years earlier. Pythagoras (or his school) gave the first known formal proof.
- **The Kerala school (1340 to 1610) anticipated parts of calculus.** Madhava's infinite series for arctangent, sine, and cosine predates Newton and Leibniz by 300 years. They had pieces of calculus, not the full framework.
- **Pingala (3rd to 2nd century BCE) had a binary enumeration and Pascal's Triangle.** Leibniz (1679, 1703) developed binary arithmetic. Modern computers use Leibniz's framing, with Pingala's combinatorics as an under-credited ancestor.
- **Panini's grammar (around 500 BCE) is one of the great intellectual achievements anywhere.** Sanskrit is not "the mother of all languages." It is one of the major Indo-European languages.
- **NASA has no Sanskrit programme.** The Rick Briggs 1985 paper is real but says something much more modest than the popular claim.
- **Aryabhata invented the sine function (jya, half-chord) in 499 CE.** The word "sine" comes from Sanskrit jya, via a famous Arabic translator's misreading, to Latin sinus.
- **India contributed major refinements to pi computation.** Madhava's series in 1400 CE is the greatest pre-European achievement on pi.
- **Indian algebra (Brahmagupta, Bhaskara II) made major contributions.** The word "algebra" is Arabic. Modern symbolic algebra is European Renaissance. The history is genuinely multi-culture.

The Pattern for This Part

The pattern here is "mostly true, with a caveat." Indian mathematics is genuinely great. The specific overclaims tend to be: "first" when others were earlier; "stolen" when credited transmission is documented; "invented all of X" when the truth is "contributed major pieces of X." The honest credit is enough. The inflated credit damages the real story.

What's Next

Part 7. History and Archaeology. The Aryan migration debate. The historicity of the Mahabharata and Ramayana. Dwarka as a real submerged city. The date of the Kurukshetra war (3102 BCE or fictional?). The Saraswati River. The Indus script. Pseudoarchaeology versus actual archaeology. The chapter where Hindutva claims about dates and locations meet what the spade and the carbon-14 lab actually say.

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Real Indian mathematics is impressive enough.

The honest credit is the most lasting credit.

LOVEPREET SINGH